



Beijing 2008

SHOOTING

Man with a Golden

An extraordinarily-driven shooter fights back injury and setbacks to record India's greatest sporting achievement, his Olympic gold bringing redemption to his sport and the nation

■ By Sharda Ugra in Beijing

Abhinav Bindra has made a promise. It's nice of him to still think he owes us. A gold medal should easily satisfy a nation of Olympic Lilliputs but no. Everyone and his blubbery breadwala is wondering about Bindra's bespectacled seriousness and that droll, somnolent voice. Why wasn't he grinning till his ears disappeared? How come he didn't handspring on to the podium, snatch the bouquet, smooch his medal and Princess Nora of Lichtenstein who gave it to him? Okay, okay, how about a wobbling chin, then, a shimmer of tears for *dharti maa*, a little bit of sniffing? It takes him four hours to reach to his parents who by then have distributed sweets to Chandigarh and surrounding districts, and he asks about his *dogs*? Is the guy really 26 or can the Nobel Prize for cosmetic surgery finally be instituted?

So, this is the promise: "When I'll be 50, I'll be wild," he says, "I'll grow hair till my shoulders. I'm saving it all up for my old age." For now, we'll just have to be satisfied with the po-faced fellow who, one fine Monday, fired a gun in Beijing and woke up everyone back home with a characteristically, chilled-out, "Hey, good morning, India."

This is India's greatest sporting achievement as it has come on the grandest stage. Arguments can be made in favour of Prakash Padukone's 1981 All England Badminton

Championship title in a more athletic sport, but really, India doesn't have to choose. It can just soak in the moment but don't expect Batra Talkies theatrics from the man who delivered it to us.

Rifle shooting is a sport not given to high fives. It revolves around stillness, silence and a purity of focus. It is who Bindra is, it is why he revels in his craft, it is why he is good for Olympic gold. Long time coach Gabriele Buhlmann calls Bindra "an old soul". The morning after, Bindra sounds young again, laughing more than he usually does. He went to Beijing's Peninsula Hotel for dinner wearing his medal when the waiters suddenly also spotted him on tv and nearly dropped their trays. Bindra's companions erupted into a pantomime of pointing and nodding. He's the man, they said, he's the one, who with scores tied, squeezed the trigger and produced the shot that set a billion people free.

The night before his competition, Bindra said he didn't sleep. "Not a wink," he told INDIA TODAY. "I was thinking about the event, I wanted to shoot. I was ready." And he was. So ready to do what he did, that when he fired his last shot at the bow-shaped Beijing shooting range in Shijingshan district, Bindra thought he'd "probably won a medal" because he'd shot a good round.

When he turned to Buhlmann, she gave him a thumbs-up, in Europe the signal for No. 1. To Bindra, it just meant "well done". He asked whether a shoot-out was needed. She shook her head

GLORIOUS SHOTS

NATIONAL CHAMPION: 1999, 2000, 2001, 2002, 2003, 2005

COMMONWEALTH GAMES, 2002, MANCHESTER: GOLD, 10M AIR RIFLE (PAIRS)

COMMONWEALTH GAMES, 2002, MANCHESTER: SILVER
EUROPEAN CIRCUIT CHAMPION, 2002: 7 GOLD, 4 SILVER, 1 BRONZE

RIAC & NISSAN CUP, 2001, 2002, 2003: GOLD

IWK MUNICH, 2001, 2003, 2004: GOLD

ALL AMERICAN CHAMPIONSHIP, 2004: GOLD

INTERSHOOT, DEN HAAG, 2002-2004: GOLD

ISAS NRW CUP, DORTMUND, 2003: GOLD



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